The Workshed Inner West Inc

Health & Safety Manual

The
Workshed Inner West Inc
BUILDING COMMUNITY CONNECTION

Health & Safety Manual

Contents

Roles & Responsibilities 4

The Workshed Inner West Inc (The Workshed) 4

Coordinator / Safety Officer 4

Members 4

Visitors 4

New Member Induction 5

Induction Checklist 5

Record Keeping 5

Inclusive & Accessible Environment 6

Membership & Inclusivity 6

Personal Health Information 6

Safety & Inclusivity 6

First Aid & Incident Management 7

First Aid 7

First Aid Kits 7

In Case of Injury 7

First Aid Register 7

Required First Aid Kit Contents 8

Incident Reporting 8

Incident management 8

Emergency Procedures 10

Fire & Burglary 11

Chemical Safety 12

Managing Chemical Spills 12

Safety Practices and Requirements 12

Guidelines for Chemical Use 13

Transferring and Labelling Chemicals 13

Chemical Storage 13

Resources 13

Hazard & Risk Management 14

What Is The Difference Between 'Hazard' And 'Risk'? 14
Step 1. Identify Hazards 15
Step 2. Assess Risks 15
Identify the Potential impact of Risk 16
Assess the Likelihood that the Risk would cause an accident 17
Action required to eliminate the Risk 17
Step 3. Control the risk 18
Control Measures 18
Examples of Risk assessments and mitigation undertaken 19
Examples of Mitigation Measures 20
Step 4. Evaluate Results 20
Assigning Responsibility 20
Regular Review Process 21
Cleanliness, Hygiene & Food Safety 22
Cleanliness 22
Hygiene Standards 22
General Hygiene: 22
Activity-Specific Hygiene: 22
General food safety 22
Specific Activity Guidelines 24
Safe Use of General Equipment 24
General Guidelines 24
Safe Use of Portable Electrical Equipment 24
Defective or Dangerous Equipment 25
Defects include: 25
Extension Leads, Flexible Cords, and Cables 25
Best Practices Checklist: 25
Ladder Safety Procedure 26
Safe Handling and Processing of Wood and Wood Based Products 27
Storage and Protection 27
Manual Handling 27

Formaldehyde 27
Machinery Safety 27
Noise 28
Wood Dust Control 28
Protective Clothing 28
Wood Finishes 29
Disposal of Wood 29
Visitors 30
Our Commitments Include: 30
Respect & Behaviour 31

Roles & Responsibilities

The Workshed Inner West Inc (The Workshed)

Coordinator / Safety Officer

- Ensure safety procedures are implemented and followed
- Conduct regular risk assessments and inspections
- Maintain incident and hazard registers
- Provide induction and training for new members
- Liaise with emergency services and external safety bodies if needed

Members

- Follow all safety procedures and use equipment responsibly
- Report hazards, incidents, or unsafe behaviour promptly
- Participate in training and induction sessions
- Support a culture of care and inclusion

Visitors

- Sign in and out upon arrival and leaving the venue
- Receive a brief safety induction
- Must be supervised at all times
- Required to follow The Workshed safety rules

New Member Induction

Induction Checklist

Each new member will be guided through The Workshed Inner West Inc New Member Induction Checklist with an authorised member of The Workshed.

Included in the checklist are:

- Welcome and introduction to The Workshed
- Overview of the association's mission, values, and activities
- Tour of the facility and explanation of facilities and amenities
- Introduction to key members, volunteers, and committee
- Review of the **[Membership Policy]** and **The Workshed [Code of Conduct Policy]**
- Review of Working with **[Vulnerable People Policy]** (if applicable)
- Explanation of safety protocols and emergency procedures
- Discussion of first aid, incident reporting, and health guidelines
- Orientation to programs and activity schedules
- Explanation of member rights and responsibilities
- Information on how to get involved or volunteer
- Overview of insurance coverage and personal responsibility
- Distribution of welcome pack or membership resources
- Sign-up to communication channels (newsletters, WhatsApp, etc.)
- Confirmation of membership form and fee (if applicable) received
- Assigned an activity risk level tag
- Questions answered and induction complete
- Sign-off The Workshed Inner West Inc New Member Induction Checklist confirming induction completion.

Record Keeping

- All inductions are documented and signed by both the member and The Workshed Coordinator.
- Records are stored securely and reviewed annually.

Inclusive & Accessible Environment

The Workshed supports the holistic wellbeing of its members by fostering inclusive, safe, and respectful environments.

We recognise that sound safety practices prevent injury, illness and property damage, builds trust within our community, ensuring the sustainability of our programs.

We are committed to providing a safe, inclusive, and welcoming environment for all members, facilitators, and visitors. Safety is not only a legal responsibility, but also a shared community value.

Membership & Inclusivity

- Facilitators must comply with The Workshed's Working with Vulnerable People Policy and the Code of Conduct.
- Members, facilitators and visitors are to be treated with respect.

Personal Health Information

- Members may be asked to disclosure relevant health information regarding the ability to safely participate in activities.
- This information helps ensure the safety and wellbeing of members.

Safety & Inclusivity

- All members, facilitators and visitors receive induction and training on safety responsibilities.
- Safety practices are continually improved through regular reviews in consultation with members and reporting.
- Physical layouts, signage and scheduling are adapted to ensure accessibility.
- Clear emergency procedures and adequate equipment are provided.
- Accessible safety information and documentation are provided as required.

First Aid & Incident Management

First Aid

Where possible, at least one volunteer or facilitator in each session should be trained in basic First Aid. First Aid training is encouraged for all facilitators and session leaders. If no-one with training is available, then an Emergency Contact or, in their absence, a Medical Practitioner should be contacted by phone for assistance with treating an injury.

First Aid Kits

- First aid kits are located **[insert location]**
- Trained first aid officers**: [insert First Aid member register]**
- Review contents monthly and replace expired or used items immediately.

In Case of Injury

- Phone a First Aid-trained member, or if unavailable, contact the participant's emergency contact.
- In all emergency cases, phone 000.
- Use the First Aid Kit and follow First Aid protocols.
- Complete the **[insert Incident Report Form]** for any injury, no matter how small.

First Aid Register

- First Aid Registers of First Aid trained members and First Aid Kits must be maintained, kept up-to-date, and reviewed periodically.
- Record trends to improve safety practices.
- **[insert First Aid member register]**
- **[insert First Aid Kits and contents register]**

Required First Aid Kit Contents

- The Workshed will maintain a full First Aid Kit which includes **[insert Comprehensive list]**
- Review contents monthly and replace expired or used items immediately.
- Maintain First Aid equipment register of incident use, replacement and expiry dates.

Incident Reporting

In the case of an incident or near miss, comply with the following:

- Notify The Workshed Coordinator or Safety Officer immediately
- Complete an Incident Report Form **[insert link to Incident Report form])** for all incidents, no matter the type or how minor.
- Document in the Incident Report Register **[insert link to Incident Report Register].**
- Serious incidents must be reported to relevant authorities within 24 hours.
- Conduct monthly review of the Incident Report Register and identify improvements.

Incident management

We commit to:

- Encouraging a culture of safety where risks are identified, reported, assessed, and controlled.
- Training and inducting all members, facilitators, and visitors on safety responsibilities.
- Continuously improving safety practices through regular reviews and updates.
- Maintaining a Safety Register including risk assessments, incident reports, and inspection records.
- Ensuring legal compliance with all applicable laws and regulations.
- Providing clear emergency procedures and adequate equipment.

- Using visual safety markers to identify designated areas such as fire and evacuation, tool zones, wet areas and activities.
- Consulting with members about safety improvements offering accessible safety information and documentation.

Emergency Procedures

In an emergency follow the **[insert link Workshed Inner West Inc. Emergency Plan]** to address events such as serious injuries, fires, floods, theft, chemical spills.

An explanation of safety protocols and emergency procedures are provided in The Workshed **[New Member Induction Checklist]**.

The following information of emergency contacts must be clearly display.

Emergency Contact	**Contact Information**
Police	000
Fire	000
Ambulance	000
Nearest Doctor	**[Insert Name & Phone]**
Nearest Hospital	**[Insert Name & Phone]**
Poisons Info Centre	13 11 26
After Hours Emergency Contact	**[Insert contact]**
Health & Safety Officer	**[Insert Name & Phone]**
First Aid Certificate holders	**[Insert Name & Phone]**

- Muster points must be identified on a **[insert link to Site Map]**.
- Emergency drills are practiced once yearly / adjust them when necessary.

Fire & Burglary

A risk assessment of fire and burglary is undertaken to consider the requirement for fire protection equipment and the appropriate type of burglary and fire alarms. The various tools, equipment and contents of The Workshed are included in the risk assessment.

Smoking is not allowed in any part of The Workshed premises in accordance with QLD laws.

Visual information is clearly displayed for:

- Fire extinguishers are located **[insert location].**
- **[Evacuation route maps and emergency contact list located near exits]**

In case of fire:

1. Raise the alarm/ phone 000
2. Evacuate calmly via the nearest exit
3. Assemble at the designated emergency muster point: **[insert link to Site Map]**
4. Do not re-enter until cleared by emergency personnel

After an incident, review existing fire safety procedures and consider any necessary improvements to help prevent future fires.

In the case of burglary:

1. Ensure personal safety
2. Notify police - phone 000
3. Do not enter or touch anything to preserve evidence
4. Wait for police

Losses will be documented and relevant notifications made. A review of the incident will be undertaken for future improvements.

Chemical Safety

- Always wear appropriate Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) when handling chemicals.
- Follow instructions detailed in Safety Data Sheets (SDS).
- Ensure all chemical containers are clearly labelled.
- Avoid direct contact with hazardous substances and wash hands thoroughly after use.
- Clean up spills promptly with suitable materials.
- Label, store, and dispose of chemicals and hazardous items safely.
- Read and comply with disposal instructions on containers.
- Wash hands before food-related activities and after handling chemicals or shared tools.
- Avoid dangerous chemicals where possible; small amounts of fuel may need to be managed.

Managing Chemical Spills

- Small fuel spills can usually be managed locally.
- Larger spills must be reported immediately by calling Emergency Number 000.
- Quick and correct action is crucial in spill incidents.

Safety Practices and Requirements

- Ensure Safety Data Sheets (SDS) are available and maintained for chemicals and materials used in the workshop. This includes paints, cleaning chemicals, adhesives and similar materials.
- Participants should wear appropriate PPE such as gloves, eye protection, or masks as required by the activity or chemical involved.
- Maintain adequate ventilation for any work involving chemicals or dust-producing materials.
- Maintain a monthly maintenance checklist to monitor stocks of perishable items and chemicals.

Guidelines for Chemical Use

- Follow all safety labels and guidance provided in the instructions for use and the Safety Data Sheets.
- Always wear appropriate PPE, including gloves, masks, and goggles, when handling chemicals.
- Seek assistance from others if unsure about handling a particular chemical.
- Handle chemicals, glues, paints, and solvents with caution, especially those with limited shelf lives. Dispose of these items correctly.
- Refer to the manufacturer's instructions and review the relevant SDS before disposing of any chemical. If uncertainty remains, contact the local Council for advice on disposal procedures.

Transferring and Labelling Chemicals

- Handle the process of transferring chemicals between containers with care.
- Always ensure the new container is clearly labelled.
- Never reuse food or drink containers for storing chemicals as this may lead to accidental poisoning.

Chemical Storage

- Use a secure, approved cupboard for storing dangerous chemicals (e.g. methylated spirits, turpentine, varnishes, linseed oil, paint strippers).
- Obtain all Safety Data Sheets (SDS) for chemicals from the supplier at the time of purchase.
- Maintain an inventory and record expiration dates for all chemicals.

Resources

Resources are available to support safety planning and chemical management such as:

Safe Work Australia Hazardous Chemical Information System (HCIS)

Diggers Australia https://diggersaustralia.com.au/safety-data-sheets for glues, solvents, paints, and general workshop chemicals,

Chemwatch Public SDS Search (Australia Wide): https://chemwatch.net/services/sds-management-safety-data-sheet/

Hazard & Risk Management

Hazard and risk management at The Workshed involves identifying, evaluating, and addressing possible dangers or threats that could impact people, property, reputation, finances, or operations. This process helps ensure the health, safety, and ongoing viability of the programs and activities provided by The Workshed.

Potential hazards include any situation that might compromise health or safety. Some risks can be dealt with straight away, such as removing a trip hazard, cleaning up a spill, or moving a regularly used item to a lower shelf to make it more accessible.

What Is The Difference Between 'Hazard' And 'Risk'?

A **'HAZARD'** means a situation or thing that has the potential to harm a person. Hazards may include:

- noisy machinery
- manually lifting or moving equipment
- chemical storage & usage
- electricity
- repetitive job at your workplace

A **'RISK'** is the possibility of physical damage to property (building fire) or personal injury (death, injury or illness) that might occur when exposed to a hazard in the Shed.

It includes two factors:

Likelihood – how likely the event is to happen

Consequence – the severity of the outcome if it does happen.

Examples of what are a Hazard and Risk

HAZARD	RISK
Frequent bending to manually unload a pallet with boxes	Incorrect manual handling technique causing injury to the back
An extension cord running across a frequently used walkway.	A trip and possible injury resulting

Step 1. Identify Hazards

Assessing a risk involves developing an understanding of each risk, its consequences and the likelihood of the risk occurring associated with The Workshed activities. The **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Activity Risk Assessment Sheet]** is completed before launching or approving any activity or program at The Workshed. The **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Risk Assessment Sheet]** is then used to document both the hazard and the relevant task or activity, and the steps necessary to eliminate the hazard and reduce risks which are identified in the Activity Risk Assessment.

The **[Risk Analysis Thinking Prompts]** can also assist in identifying common hazards and assessing the Risk.

Step 2. Assess Risks

When the hazards are identified, the level of risk and consequences needs to be established. The risk assessment matrix is used to identify the likelihood of a risk causing injury, illness or damage to health and safety and the risk level.

Below is an example of a risk assessment matrix commonly utilised by government departments to describe, analyse, assess, rate and control hazards or risks.

Likelihood	Consequences				
	Negligible / Insignificant	Low / Minor	Medium / Moderate	Very high / Major	Extreme / Critical
Rare	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	HIGH Quarterly senior management review
Unlikely	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	HIGH Quarterly senior management review
Possible	LOW Consider accepting the risk or routine management	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	HIGH Quarterly senior management review	HIGH Quarterly senior management review
Likely	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	HIGH Quarterly senior management review	HIGH Quarterly senior management review	EXTREME Monthly senior management review
Almost certain	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	MEDIUM Specify responsibility and action	HIGH Quarterly senior management review	EXTREME Monthly senior management review	EXTREME Monthly senior management review

To assess the risk associated with each hazard and assess whether it is low risk, medium risk, very high risk or an extreme risk, use the Risk Matrix and ask:

1. **How likely is the risk to cause someone harm?**
   - Would it be a rare event, possible or almost certain?
   - How frequently are members exposed to the risk?

2. **What is the potential impact of the risk?**
   - How severe could an injury or illness be?
   - What is the worst possible damage the risk could cause to someone's health & safety?
   - Would it require simple first aid or cause permanent personal or property damage

For each activity **[The Workshed Inner West Inc – Activity Risk Assessment Checklist]** is to be completed before launching or approving any activity or program at or associated with The Workshed. The checklist includes risk assessment of physical, emotional, legal and operational risk across all current activity types and serves as a record of identified risks, actions taken, and the status of each item, helping to promote accountability and ongoing risk mitigation. Risk assessments are reviewed monthly be the management committee and recorded in the **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Comprehensive Risk Assessment Register].**

Identify the Potential impact of Risk

Insignificant	No injuries, low financial loss
Minor	Simple First aid treatment, medium financial loss
Moderate	Significant First aid treatment, high financial loss
Major	Extensive injuries, loss of production capability, major financial loss
Catastrophic	Death, huge financial loss

Assess the Likelihood that the Risk would cause an accident

Almost certain	The event is **expected to occur** in most circumstances
Likely	The event **will probably occur** in most circumstances
Moderate	The event **should** occur at some time
Unlikely	The event **could** occur at some time
Rare	The event may occur **only in exceptional circumstances**

Action required to eliminate the Risk

High	High Risk - act immediately to take steps to Fix the Problem
Significant	Significant risk - act immediately to take steps to Fix the Problem
Moderate	Moderate risk - act as soon as practicable
Low	Low risk -manage by routine procedures and reassess within designated timeframe

Step 3. Control the risk

Systematically working through the **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Activity Risk Assessment Checklist]** identifies a hazard and assesses the risk, risk controls are developed or updated to mitigate future risks and recorded on **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Comprehensive Risk Register].** Working through risks in this way is known as the hierarchy of control. Risks are identified and a control or controls are put in place to measure and reduce the exposure to risks. The Workshed always aims to remove a hazard when identified.

Control Measures

Control measures are actions taken to reduce, eliminate or manage risk and hazards that have been identified. They follow the hierarchy of the following controls.

1. **Eliminate the risk.**
   - For example, repair damaged equipment; use a lifting machine to do the lifting in the workplace; stop using a dangerous chemical.

If this is not practical, then:

2. **Substitute the risk with a safer alternative.**
   - For example, break larger loads down into smaller, lighter loads; use a less toxic chemical.

If this is not practical, then:

3. **Isolate the risk.**
   - For example, install barriers to restrict access to risky work areas or machines; use chemicals in a safe dedicated work area.

If this is not practical, then:

4. **Use engineering controls**
   - For example, place guards on dangerous parts of machinery; use a trolley to move heavy loads; explore use of localised extraction systems.

If this is not practical, then:

5. **Use administrative controls**
    - For example: have clear safety notices on machines; change work practices and organisation; rotate jobs to reduce the time spent on any single task; train members in safe work procedures; carry out routine maintenance of equipment.

If this is not practical, then:

6. **Use personal PPE**
    - For example, provide workers with PPE such as gloves, masks or ear muffs and train members to use PPE correctly.

Risk control primarily aims to prevent or reduce the likelihood of a risk while mitigation focuses on reducing the severity or impact because of a risk occurring. Both are used to manage the uncertainty, with the control being a preventive action and mitigation being a corrective action.

Examples of Risk assessments and mitigation undertaken

Activity	Risk	Mitigation
Wellness class	Participant with trauma triggered	Completed consent form, trained facilitator
Walking group	Trip or fall injury, dehydration	Risk briefing, first aid kit, walk leaders, suitable clothing, water
Sewing or DIY	Needle or tool injury	Induction, supervised use, PPE
Paints or glues	Allergic reaction or chemical exposure	SDS available, PPE, all products labelled
Food at events	Allergies or food poisoning	Label food, follow food safety
Online accounts	Account or data breach	Use secure passwords, limit access, cloud backups

Examples of Mitigation Measures

- Display emergency plans, first aid location.
- Use waiver and screening forms for trauma-sensitive activities.
- Keep chemicals labelled and SDSs on file.
- Store tools securely and monitor their use.
- Have a backup plan for sessions (e.g. alternate facilitator list).
- Maintain the **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Comprehensive Risk Assessment Register]** and track all incidents.

Step 4. Evaluate Results

Risk management is a continuous process, and it is essential to regularly evaluate the effectiveness of any changes implemented to mitigate hazards and risks. Consult with members and ask:

- Has the change made a difference?
- Is the change effective in reducing or eliminating risks preventing injury or illness?
- Have changes created new risks or increased the risk of existing ones?
- Are there any other ways we can implement to make further improvement?

Assigning Responsibility

It is important to clearly allocate tasks to the relevant committee members, facilitators and members involved in a program or activity. The following roles should be considered when distributing responsibilities:

- **Committee members:** Assign decision-making and oversight duties to committee members to ensure effective management and governance.
- **Facilitators:** Allocate specific tasks and responsibilities to facilitators, focusing on program delivery and participant engagement.
- **Members** or safety officers: Clearly define duties for volunteers or safety officers, particularly those related to safety, support, and risk management.

Maintain the **[The Workshed Inner West Inc Comprehensive Risk Assessment Register]** to track assigned actions and ensure follow-up.

Regular Review Process

Ongoing regular reviews are conducted to ensure effective risk management. Risks should be assessed prior to the commencement of a new program or activity at the start of each term or program cycle to identify new or emerging issues. Procedures should be re-evaluated after any incident or near miss to prevent recurrence. Additionally, risk management procedures should be updated annually to incorporate lessons learned, changes in activities, and best practice improvements.

Cleanliness, Hygiene & Food Safety

Cleanliness

All members of The Workshed are expected and agree to maintain personal cleanliness and respect for each other, equipment and shared spaces.

Hygiene Standards

The Workshed offers a range of activities from outdoor walking to indoor craft and wellness sessions. Each activity requires appropriate hygiene standards:

General Hygiene:

- All members are expected to maintain personal cleanliness and respect shared spaces.

Activity-Specific Hygiene:

- **Creative & DIY activities** (e.g., sewing, bilum-making, woodwork): Workspaces and shared tools must be cleaned before and after use.
- **Wellness programs** (eg. Rasa, meditation): Floors, mats, surfaces and equipment used are to be sanitised between sessions.
- **Shared equipment & materials** (eg. Yarn, utensils and tools): Avoid sharing items that come into contact with the mouth, eyes or skin unless sanitised.

Facilitators and members are responsible for enforcing hygiene standards appropriate to the activity.

General food safety

- Wash hands before handling food utensils and equipment.
- Use clean utensils and surfaces before and after making tea or coffee
- Dispose of used tea bags, coffee grounds, and any food scraps properly.
- Remove kitchen waste regularly.
- Launder towels and cloths used for cleaning and drying kitchen equipment.
- Store milk and other perishables in the fridge.

- Regularly remove expired items from the fridge and use a simple dating system for ingredients.
- Check for any signs of mould or leaks near sinks or kettles, and report issues if found.

For more detailed information, refer to the Brisbane City Council guidelines on Food Safety regulations.

Specific Activity Guidelines

Safe Use of General Equipment

To ensure a safe environment for all members and visitors, only trained and assessed members may operate machinery in line with operating and safety standards. Members must always comply with safety standards. This includes never using equipment under influence of drugs, alcohol, or impairing medication. If a fault is found with equipment, always report it to the shed coordinator or volunteer of the shed.

All tools and materials including machines, saws, paints, hot glue are checked for safety and proper disposal. Chemicals and hazardous items must be labelled, stored safely, and disposed of properly. Manual handling rules apply to lifting equipment, shared storage, and setup/pack-down. PPE (gloves, glasses, masks) is provided as needed.

General Guidelines

- Use only tools you are trained on.
- Check tools for damage or wear before each use.
- Wear task-appropriate PPE (glasses, ear protection, gloves).
- Keep workspaces tidy.
- Never leave powered tools unattended.
- Store tools

Safe Use of Portable Electrical Equipment

All portable electrical equipment used at The Workshed must meet strict safety standards. Members using power tools and appliances must be trained and assessed at the appropriate risk level identified per the **[Member Woodwork Assessment Form]**.
All electrically powered tools, appliances, lights, and chargers must:

- Use only tools you are trained on.
- Be connected via an approved Earth Leakage Protection Device (RCD).
- Be clearly identifiable and checked before every use.
- Be tested and tagged by a qualified technician at least once every 12 months, in accordance with the Australian Code of Practice for Electrical Equipment.
- Not be exposed to liquids.

If any electrical item has fallen into water or been exposed to other liquid, excessive moisture, steam or condensation, **DO NOT TOUCH** until the item is safely isolated from power and has been dried, tested and tagged safe by a licensed electrician.

Defective or Dangerous Equipment

The person in charge of operations or programs has full authority to:

- Remove any faulty equipment from use immediately
- Tag it clearly as “Out of Service”
- Ensure it is isolated from power and reported for inspection or disposal

Defects include:

- Exposed wires or damaged insulation
- Loose or poorly secured plugs
- Cracked casings or overheating signs
- Damaged cords or broken switches

Extension Leads, Flexible Cords, and Cables

To reduce trip, fire, and electrocution risks, all cables must:

- Be visually inspected before every use
- Be stored off the floor whenever possible
- If in regular use, be secured at a height of at least 2.4 metres
- Never be placed through walkways or under rugs
- Frayed, twisted, or kinked leads must be removed and tagged Out of Service.

Best Practices Checklist:

- ☐ RCD protection used on every outlet
- ☐ Test & Tag log maintained annually
- ☐ Leads safely suspended or secured
- ☐ Damaged items removed and tagged
- ☐ Only licensed electricians repair equipment
- ☐ Members trained to report faults

Ladder Safety Procedure

Ladders are essential tools at The Workshed, particularly during setup, storage access, or occasional maintenance tasks. To ensure safety and prevent injury, the following procedures apply to all members, facilitators, volunteers and visitors.
Ladder use should only be undertaken by members who are physically capable and confident. All ladder activities must be conducted during open shed hours with a second person nearby. Display ladder safety signage in the work zone area and never use a ladder which is damaged.

WorkSafe Queensland -Managing the risk of falls at workplaces Code of Practice 2021 provides detailed guidance on working with ladders.

Step 1 Setting Up the Ladder

- Inspect for damage: Check the ladder for cracks, bent, worn ropes, faulty pulleys, or missing locking gear.
- Correct angle: Set the ladder at a 4:1 slope (75 degrees). For every 4 metres of height, position the base 1 metre out from the wall.
- Secure it: Ensure it is fixed or held securely at the top and bottom to avoid slipping or movement.
- Extend properly: If accessing a platform or roof, the ladder must extend 1 metre above the platform.
- Do not place:
- In front of doors unless locked or guarded
- Against windows or electrical wires/conductors
- On scaffolding or work platforms to gain extra height

Step 2 Climbing the Ladder

- When ascending or descending:
- Use both hands
- Only one person on the ladder at a time
- Do not climb higher than the third rung from the top
- A second person must be present to steady the ladder; they are advised to wear a hard hat
- Do not carry loose tools or materials—hoist or pass them up separately

Step 3. Working on a Ladder

- Face the ladder at all times during work
- Do not overreach—reposition the ladder instead
- Only use one-handed tools when working on ladders
- After use, store the ladder in a dry, well-ventilated space, off the ground, and supported horizontally to prevent warping or sagging.

Safe Handling and Processing of Wood and Wood Based Products

Storage and Protection

- Store particleboard, hardboard, plywood, and MDF in dry, well-ventilated areas.
- Moisture changes in panels can cause bowing and may pinch the saw blade during cutting.
- Sawn timber that has been dried should be stored and handled like panel products.
- Unseasoned timber not used immediately should be block stacked on level ground or on suitable bearers.

Manual Handling

- Follow manufacturer's specifications for safe manual handling practices.
- In seated work, avoid lifting loads heavier than 4.5 kg.
- Standing lifts should generally remain below 16–20 kg to reduce back injury risk.
- Use mechanical or team lifting for heavier loads to prevent injuries.
- No individual should lift, lower, or carry more than 55 kg without assistance.

Formaldehyde

- Wood panels like particleboard, MDF, plywood, laminated veneer timber, and laminated beams may use adhesives containing formaldehyde.
- Store these materials in a well-ventilated area to help reduce formaldehyde emissions as they can emit small amounts of formaldehyde into the air,

Machinery Safety

- Identify all potential hazards associated with machinery.
- Assess the risk each hazard poses.
- Eliminate or reduce risks wherever possible.
- Install guards and safety devices to protect users.
- Ensure woodworking machines are properly guarded to prevent injuries from cutting tools.
- Restrict access to moving cutters using appropriate guards.
- Locate and check emergency stop buttons prior to operating machinery.

Noise

Even if noise levels are below that which may damage hearing, it can contribute to other dangers by masking warning signals and hindering communication. Whenever possible, noise levels should be reduced by engineering controls. Any person working in a high noise area should wear personal hearing protection.

Wood Dust Control

Wood dust from machining or sanding can irritate eyes, skin, and the respiratory system. Prolonged exposure may increase cancer risk, especially in the nasal area. Machining preservative-treated wood adds chemical risks, so precautions are necessary. Use a well-maintained dust extraction system and ensure good ventilation; if unavailable, wear an approved dust mask and eye protection.

MDF and hardboard produce finer dust than solid wood or plywood, requiring higher-efficiency extraction. Dust from particleboard needs extraction systems with capture velocities of 10–20 m/sec, while MDF and hardwoods require 20–30 m/sec. Increasing capture velocity can be achieved by reducing hood size and placing them close to dust sources. Close off ducts not in use, but maintain minimum air velocity in active ducting—15–20 m/sec for fine dust—to prevent buildup.

High concentrations of wood dust can be explosive, so fit ducting with vents. Clean up dust using vacuum or wet sweeping, not compressed air; if compressed air is used, always wear proper respiratory protection.

Protective Clothing

In addition to dust masks, eye and hearing protection there is also clothing, some woods and wood dusts can contain naturally occurring chemicals which may cause dermatitis and asthma in some people. At all times it is recommended to use long sleeve shirts and gloves to avoid skin contact.

Wood Finishes

Many of the finishes applied to wood and wood products, such as paints, lacquers and varnishes, contain solvents and other chemicals which may have possible health effects. It is important that all materials be checked for to ensure their safe use. Safety Data Sheet (SDS) should be obtained from the manufacturer, and labels on the container should be examined for information about possible health effects and how to avoid them.

Disposal of Wood

Most wood can be disposed of at landfill sites or by incineration, although increasing emphasis is being placed on recycling materials. The exception can be wood that has been treated with chemicals.

Before disposal of treated wood, reference should be made to the National Occupational Health and Safety Guidelines on the handling of treated wood products and to local regulations regarding landfill disposal. Landfill disposal may be permitted under controlled conditions.

Combustion of treated and painted wood should be avoided as both may contain chemicals which can release toxic fumes when burned, posing health and environmental risks.

Visitors

The Workshed requires visitors to complete a safety briefing tailored to their work upon arrival, and visitor badges should be worn when available. All visitors must adhere to posted signage, wear closed shoes, and use the necessary PPE.

At The Workshed, we are dedicated to fostering a safe, inclusive, and welcoming environment for all members and visitors. Safety is both a legal obligation and a core value of our community. We acknowledge that effective safety practices:

- Prevent injuries, illnesses, and property damage
- Strengthen trust within our community
- Meet our compliance requirements
- Support the long-term viability of our programs.

Our Commitments Include:

- Promoting of a culture of safety where risks are proactively identified, reported, assessed, and mitigated.
- Conducting of safety training and induction for all members, volunteers, facilitators, and visitors.
- Continuing improvement of safety standards through regular evaluation and enhancement of procedures.
- Maintaining a comprehensive Safety Register containing risk assessments, incident reports, and inspection records.
- Ensuring compliance with all relevant legislation and regulatory requirements.
- Providing clear emergency protocols and appropriate safety equipment.
- Engaging with members regarding potential safety improvements.
- Supplying accessible and up-to-date safety information and documentation.

Respect & Behaviour

At The Workshed, we foster a respectful, inclusive, and positive environment where women are supported and empowered to thrive. We uphold clear policies and proactive practices to ensure the safety and wellbeing of all members and visitors, including regular safety training, comprehensive inductions, and ongoing reviews of our procedures. By maintaining detailed safety records, complying with regulations, and encouraging active member participation, we build community trust and sustain our programs in a welcoming and supportive space.